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UNIFIL Operational Strategy: A Three-Pronged Approach

The preceding sections discussed the planning of the UNIFIL enhancement at different levels, ranging from the high political level of the Security Council over the different aspects of the UN bureaucracy down to the level of operational planning in the field. It is now time to replace this descriptive focus with an analytical mindset and draw all aspects together in an assessment of UNIFIL's strategic logic. This means answering the question how UNIFIL's forces and capabilities on the ground are being put to use in function of the political objectives as set out in the mandate. In a nutshell, this section argues that UNIFIL strategy has three dimensions: (i) UNIFIL constitutes a military buffer that both conflict parties try to exploit as a security shield, (ii) UNIFIL provides a de-escalation mechanism through its liaison functions, and (iii) UNIFIL enables and contributes to reconstruction, not in the least through its own economic footprint.

UNIFIL as a Military Buffer

It is the first dimension that is most fraught with controversy. What is the purely military logic behind a peacekeeping force that is in the possession of formidable capabilities – for UN standards – but whose hands are tied by a restrictive mandate? The enhanced UNIFIL cannot do very much beyond showing its presence because it has conceptually remained the same old UNIFIL: it is a force based on the consent of the Lebanese government that acts in support of the LAF. Its new rules of engagement are robust in the sense that the authority to use force is delegated to the lowest possible level, but they remain based on the principle of self-defence. For all other situations, UNIFIL can do nothing else than ask the LAF to take the lead. As one officer ironically remarked: “Aha, we can call the LAF – now everybody starts shaking with fear!”

In discussions with planners, strategic concepts like containment and deterrence featured prominently. These concepts need to be understood in a political sense: the massive presence of UNIFIL may change the way the conflict parties make their cost-benefit analysis. From a public relations perspective, direct confrontations with blue helmets are costly. It can therefore be argued, for example, that the idea of an Israeli Merkava tank facing a French Leclerc tank may instil some restraint in the heads of Israeli decision-makers. Similarly, Hezbollah as well needs to consider domestic politics when defining its posture vis-à-vis the UN: it does not want to be seen as the force driving the country to war again. Yet this

notion of purely diplomatic deterrence does not equate with deterrence or containment in a military sense of threatening retaliation. Militarily speaking, UNIFIL is in no position to stop the IDF in case of a new invasion. Similarly, if Hezbollah forces are able to resist the IDF, they will not be stopped by the use of force by UN peacekeepers with fewer capabilities and even less political incentive to do so.

This notion of diplomatic deterrence is the de facto foundation of the well-known peacekeeping strategy of interposing a buffer force between conflict parties. UNIFIL shields both conflict parties from each other. But like any shield, the UNIFIL presence is not impenetrable. Israeli incursions into Lebanese airspace occur on a daily basis. Similarly, Hezbollah actively maintains arms caches and bunkers within UNIFIL's area of operations.¹⁹ While UNIFIL continuously tries to balance the political sensitivities of both parties and maintain its own credibility, this impartiality is under constant siege as the conflict parties attempt to exploit this shielding buffer to their advantage. *On the one hand, Hezbollah insists that UNIFIL's mandate is to support the LAF*. Considering the fact that the LAF cannot confront Hezbollah without fearing a split along sectarian lines, there is some room for manoeuvre to maintain arms caches in the safety of private homes in the south, as UNIFIL cannot independently search private property unless there is credible evidence of a violation of Resolution 1701. To the benefit of Hezbollah, the presence of UNIFIL restrains Israel and the UN is used for monitoring and condemning Israeli violations of Lebanese airspace. Israel, on the other hand, insists that UNIFIL's mandate is to ensure its area of operations is not used for hostile activities. The IDF occasionally provides UNIFIL forces with intelligence about arms smuggling and caches and requests for investigations into suspected sites. Sometimes this leads to a wild goose chase in the middle of the night, with UNIFIL patrols conducting investigations guided by near real-time Israeli intelligence. In a cynical interpretation, UNIFIL can be portrayed as a proxy force that pushes Israel's adversaries further away from Israeli territory.

Both parties thus emphasize that particular part of the UNIFIL mandate that serves their interests best. In an extreme interpretation, this even reduces the role of UNIFIL to a subcontractor of the IDF or the LAF. From a Lebanese perspective, UNIFIL constitutes extra manpower for the LAF to monitor the border in the south. From an Israeli perspective, UNIFIL is useful as a means to severely

19. Until recently, the existence of such caches was a matter of debate, wherein UNIFIL's political officials – in sharp contrast to their military colleagues – maintained there was no hard proof to support this thesis. However, a recent incident provided conclusive evidence. On 14 July 2009, an arms cache exploded in Kherbet Selm, a small village in the middle of UNIFIL's area of operations. The UN investigation that ensued, which was inter alia obstructed by armed militiamen, concluded that the depot was actively maintained and as such constituted a serious violation of Resolution 1701.

curtail the freedom of movement of Hezbollah and other resistance groups. This strategy of inserting a buffer that is as impartial as possible of course depends on the willingness of troop contributors to put forces on the frontline. Considering the massive presence of UNIFIL in the south, a resumption of large-scale hostilities is bound to lead to significant casualties amongst the blue helmets. UNIFIL maintains its credibility by saturating the terrain with patrols in reaction to any incident. This massive presence, conversely, also means UNIFIL is too ubiquitous to hide if fighting would break out. Whether these implications are well understood in the capitals of the UNIFIL troop contributors is a matter of debate.

UNIFIL as a Mechanism for De-Escalation

The second dimension of UNIFIL's strategy is its role as a mediator working tirelessly to de-escalate any confrontation that may occur between the LAF and the IDF. One of the important innovations in UNIFIL's new mandate was its role in coordinating between the LAF and the IDF as the former deployed and the latter withdrew. Only hours after the ceasefire, the UNIFIL Force Commander hosted a meeting where an IDF and a LAF general could coordinate their plans. Later on such meetings were institutionalised on a strategic as well as operational level. The LAF and IDF leadership would continue to meet under the tripartite forum to address military-strategic issues (e.g. the marking of the Blue Line, warnings about upcoming training manoeuvres etc.). Furthermore, a set of UNIFIL liaison officers would mediate the small day-to-day confrontations between both sides (Blue line violations etc.). Such liaison work serves both as a confidence-building measure and as a way to prevent small incidents from developing into potential conflict triggers. While the importance of keeping lines of communications open cannot be over-emphasised, it is equally true that these channels are often used for complaints that seem trivial to an outsider, such as cattle crossing the Blue Line to go and drink from a pond on the other side or water flowing from one side of the border to the other during heavy rainfall.

UNIFIL as a Reconstruction Enabler

The third dimension of UNIFIL's strategic logic, lastly, is the role it plays in the reconstruction of the area. In the immediate aftermath of the conflict in 2006, the engineering capacity that was deployed was put to use in repairing the damaged infrastructure as well as coordinating and participating in the demining efforts – to the benefit of the local population as well as UNIFIL itself. Over

time, as the need for 'direct' reconstruction receded, a more indirect way of economic reconstruction developed. Through its CIMIC activities and, even more, its outsourcing to local contractors, UNIFIL has developed into an important factor in the local economy. While this is to some extent a simple by-product of its presence rather than an intentional objective, the fact that it is also publicly perceived as such has important political as well as military consequences, e.g. in securing the local support for UNIFIL's presence and contributing to force protection and situational awareness.

Together, this trinity forms the core of UNIFIL's operational-strategic logic. All three elements are important: the first one was treated at greatest length because it is so controversial and open for interpretation. The conclusion of this assessment is that UNIFIL contributes to containing the outbreak of renewed hostilities but does not address the underlying conflict dynamics, which are political in nature and go far beyond UNIFIL's mandate. The content of the tripartite talks is obviously restricted to what the parties want to talk about, and so far the discussions have been limited to the military-technical realm. Issues with obvious political connotations, such as the issue of kidnapped soldiers, are kept off the agenda. As senior officials admit, it is very hard to envisage any sort of end-state under these conditions. UNIFIL's role in containing a new war, furthermore, is limited to de-escalating any potential conflict triggers and changing the cost-benefit calculations of the parties concerned. Yet if push comes to shove, it has neither the mandate nor the capabilities to enforce peace.